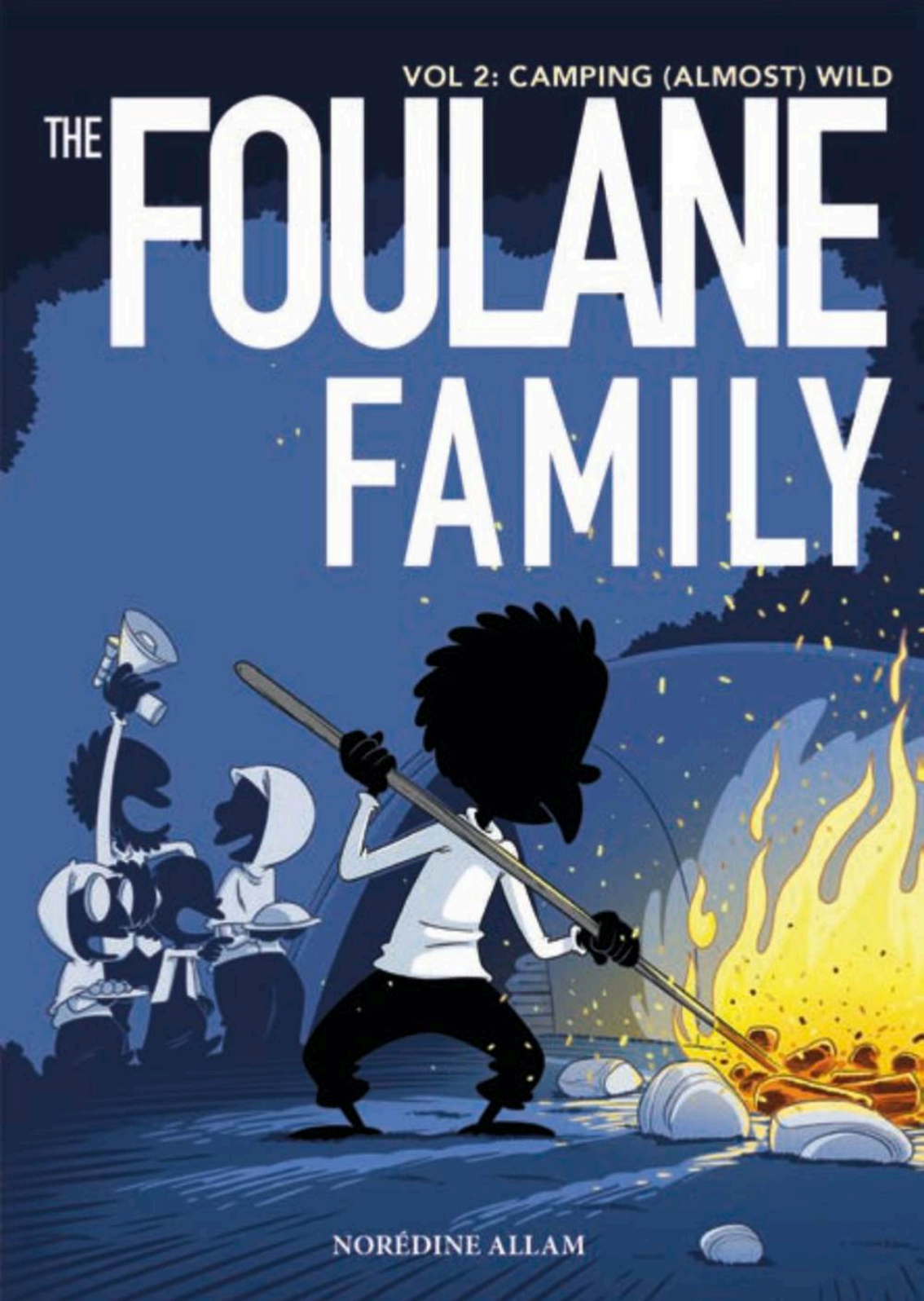
VOL 2: CAMPING (ALMOST) WILD

THE FOULANE FAMILY



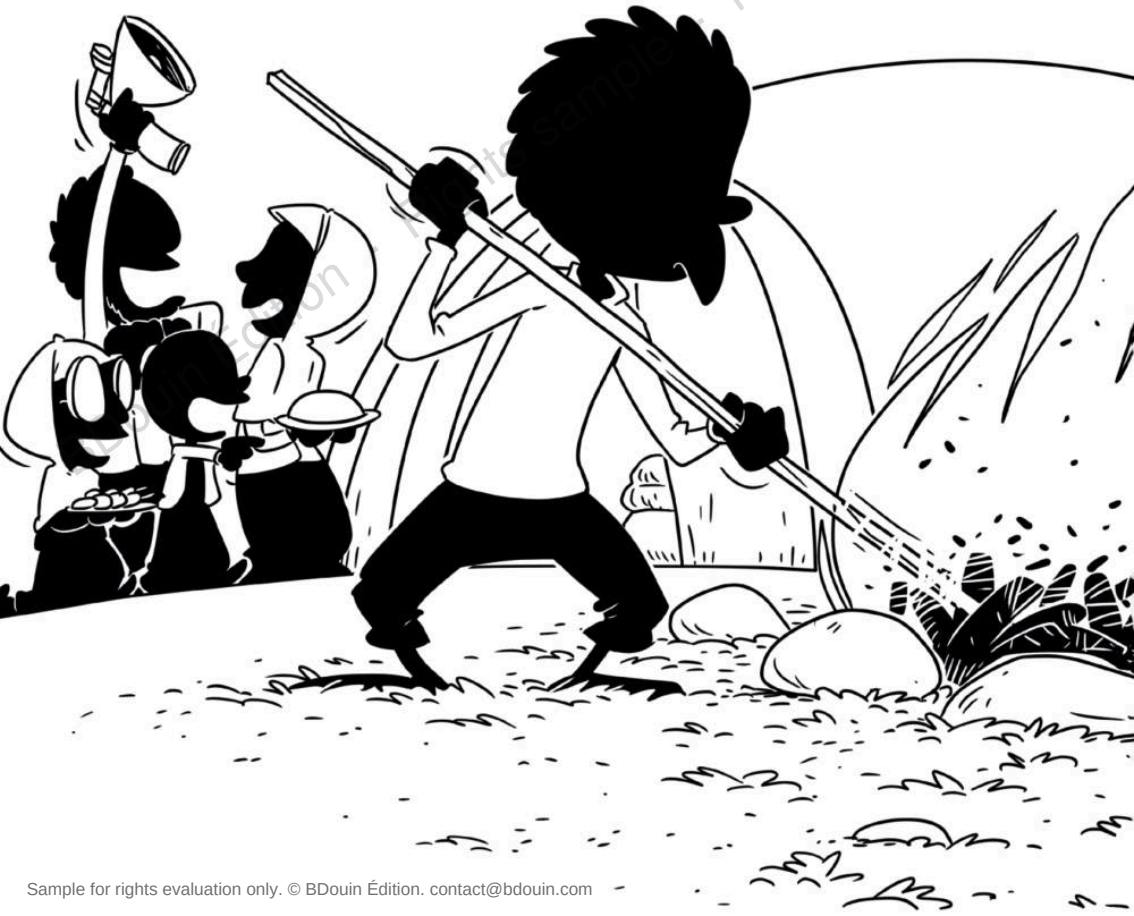
NORÉDINE ALLAM

THE FOULANE FAMILY

Vol 2. Camping in the (almost) wilderness

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THE FOULANE FAMILY

Vol.2

Camping in the (almost) wilderness

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Assalaamu ‘alaikum!

I’m going to tell you about an adventure that happened during my last half term break. It was in the Autumn.

It had all started off on the wrong foot…

Me and Binti had already been on holiday for two days, and boredom had started to set in.



I missed my school friends and was bored with being stuck at home all day long. Although the Autumn half term break is usually my favourite, this time it was different.

A few days ago, Abi had decided to renovate the garden. The Summer had been hot and the sun had been deadly for the lawn.

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With the help of a friend, he had plowed the soil, removed the weeds, and spread a new special fertilser to get an even greener grass.

To protect the growth, Me and Binti were not allowed to walk in the garden for several weeks.



Still, Abi had indeed left us a small free corner near the tree, but... that same evening, a storm had hit the town!

You may ask “What’s the problem?” Well, during the storm, a heavy downpour turned our lovely garden into a terrible muddy terrain!

And our little patch of grass near the tree had become a big brown mud pit filled with earthworms.

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And let's just say that Oummi wasn't too keen on letting us play in it...
Too bad, we would've had a lot of fun with our friends!



Speaking of friends, that was also a problem.

Usually, during the holidays, Rachid and Jeremy always come to my house to play.

Since they live far away, Rachid's mum brings them over. But a few days ago, she sprained her ankle when stepping on a manhole cover!

Rachid explained it to us at break time:

"My mum's shoe heel got stuck in the hole of a manhole cover, and when she fell, her whole body turned 360 degrees – except for her ankle!"

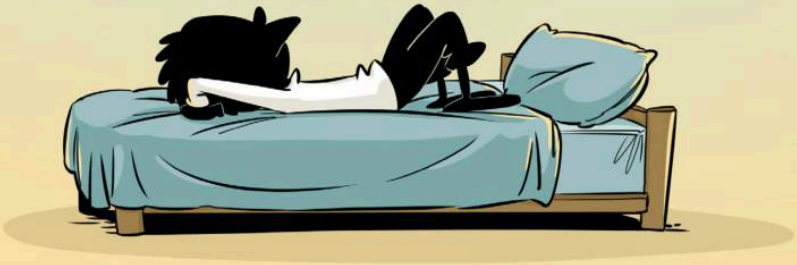
Jeremy says it wasn't possible because only an owl's neck can turn 360 degrees.

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Rachid insisted and wanted to show us how his mum did it, but then he ended up hurting his ankle and had to go to accident and emergency.



To cut a long story short, without a garden and without my friends, this break had not started well, until...



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1. An adventure!

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On the third day of half term, as me and Binti were playing with paper planes, Abi called the whole family to the living room.



Generally, when he does that, it's because he has something important to tell us. And when he does it with a smile in his beard, it usually means that it's going to be very good news for the whole family!

"Bismillah," Abi said to begin. "All praise is due to Allah, and may the praises and blessings of Allah be upon our beloved Prophet Muhammad, sallallahu 'alayhi wa sallam."

"Ameen!" said Binti.

"Alright!" continued Abi in a serious tone. "I can see that this half term break hasn't started off well for the family. And this whole mud situation in the garden has slightly contributed to that, I admit..."

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"Slightly..?" said Oummi.

"Well, yeah... it's just a little bit of mud..." Abi replied in a similarly light tone.

"A LITTLE BIT?!" Oummi's voice became a bit heavier. "Might I remind you that I have to wear WELLIES just to go and hang the washing out in the garden!"



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"Anyway...!" Abi said, trying to wrap up the topic. "I was saying that I take responsibility for the current situation, and that, therefore..."

"THEREFORE?!" Binti asked, impatient to find out what Abi was trying to tell us.

"Therefore," Abi added, "I've decided that we'll go away for a few days to get some fresh air together as a family!"

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“REALLY?!” I exclaimed, shouting with joy.

That was a surprise that nobody at home had expected. Abi works a lot and never has time to go out with us.

Also, he often says that we need to save up to be able to go on our Hajj together, insha’Allah.

As a result, our last outing was at least three years ago!

“But... do you have anything specific in mind?” Oummi asked.

“Yes, of course!” Abi replied. “We’re going to go CAMPING in the countryside! Isn’t that great?!”



“Wooow!!” I shouted, even louder. “That’s amazing! I’ve always dreamt of going camping! And will we sleep in a tent?!”

“Yes, and in a great tent for that matter!” said Abi.

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“Even at nighttime?” I asked.

“Well, yes... we usually sleep in the nighttime, Walad.” replied Abi.

“Even Oummi?!”

I asked because Oummi didn’t seem very enthusiastic about sleeping in a tent.

Even Binti, who usually likes outings, was making a face.

“In any case, I don’t want to sleep in a tent with bugs in it!” said Binti. “And sleeping outside is actually quite dangerous...”

“Nonsense!” I replied. “And anyway, Abi will be there to protect us. Right, Abi?”

“Of course!” he replied, to reassure me. “But I knew that the girls wouldn’t be very happy about this kind of outing. So, I decided that we’ll go camping in Grandma DIY’s huge back garden. The girls can sleep comfortably in Grandma DIY’s house if they don’t want to join us in the garden.”

“Wow! That’s great!” Shouted Binti with excitement.



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"That's actually a very good idea!" said Oummi, who had found her smile again too. "It's been a long time since we've seen her and I think she'll be very happy to host us at her place insha'Allah."

So there were now two pieces of good news:

1. Going camping
2. Seeing Grandma DIY

This half term break was already shaping up to one of the best I would ever experience insha'Allah!

"When are we leaving, Abi?" I asked, impatiently.

"We leave first thing tomorrow insha'Allah!" Abi shouted, standing on his armchair.



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2. The Great Departure

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I'd been awake practically the whole night, so eager was I go to camping for the first time. And judging by how Binti looked, she probably hadn't slept much more than me either.



Abi had pre-warned us that we would need to have breakfast immediately after Fajr prayer, and then we would hit the road straight after.

"Starting early in the morning is a Sunnah, kids." Abi said while we were eating. "The Prophet, sallallahu 'alayhi wa sallam, used to like to set out early on a campaign."

"Did they go camping back then too?" I asked.

"No, Walad." said Oummi. "A campaign means a military expedition... and if the Prophet, sallallahu 'alayhi wa sallam, took part in it, it was called a Ghazwa."

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"Ah yes!" I replied. "Like the Ghazwa of Khaybar where it is reported that the companion 'Ali had lifted the huge gate of the fortress all by himself!"

"Exactly!" said Abi. "And so as I was saying, leaving early is very beneficial. So finish up your breakfast quickly, we'll head off soon!"



After finishing our breakfast and cleaning the table, me and Binti went to fetch our bags.

It was fortunate that Oummi had helped us prepare them the day before.

Since we were only planning to stay for four days, we only brought the bare essentials... except for Binti.

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